

M1T2: Understanding Cravings and Triggers — 12 min

Video File M1T2-Cravings.mp4 · **Resources** Triggers Worksheet.pdf · **Xp** 90 total · Identify 3 Triggers 40 · Log Cravings for 3 Days 30 · Forum Discussion 20

Target runtime 12 min · 1,561 spoken words · ≈ 10.4 min at 150 wpm · ≈ 11.6 min at a warm 135 wpm

0:00–0:30 HOOK

[VISUAL: Cynthia on camera. Quick B-roll flashes: a hand reaching into a pantry at 9 p.m., a phone lighting up with a food ad, a desk drawer of candy.]

It's nine o'clock at night. Dinner was fine. You're not hungry. And yet you're standing in front of the pantry with the door open, and a voice in your head is saying, "Just a little." If you've ever felt that pull and then felt ashamed of it afterward, I want to tell you something right now: a craving is not a character flaw. It's a signal. And in the next twelve minutes I'm going to teach you how to read it.

0:30–2:00 WHY THIS MATTERS FOR CONCEPTION

[VISUAL: Slide: "Cravings are signals, not weaknesses."]

I've spent most of my career with people who felt hijacked by food, and I've spent a good part of my life being one of them. What I learned, first in my own body and then alongside many, many conversations, is that cravings have grammar.

They have triggers, patterns, and timing. And once you can see the pattern, you get your choice back.

That matters enormously in the months before conception, because the foods we crave most, sugar and refined carbohydrates, are exactly the ones that push insulin up and down in ways that ripple all the way through your hormones. We'll get to that biology in a moment. But I want the frame to be clear from the start: this training is about awareness, not restriction. I'm not going to ask you to give anything up this week. We're going to make friends with the signal before we ever try to change it, because you can't change what you can't see.

2:00–6:00 THE SCIENCE OF CRAVINGS

[VISUAL: Brain animation: the reward pathway lights up from the midbrain to the nucleus accumbens as a sugary food appears.]

Let's start in the brain. When you taste something sweet, especially something engineered to be sweet, a chemical messenger called dopamine surges through your reward pathway. Now, dopamine isn't really the pleasure chemical, the way it's usually described. It's the wanting chemical. It says, "That was important. Remember it. Do it again." Dr.

Nora Volkow and her colleagues at the National Institutes of Health described this in the journal *Trends in Cognitive Sciences*: highly palatable foods tap into the same motivational circuitry that drives other compulsive behaviors. The more often the surge, the more the brain expects it, and the louder the wanting gets. That's why "just a little" so rarely stays little. The brain isn't broken. It's learning exactly what it's being taught.

Here's a detail that changed how I eat. Researchers at Boston Children's Hospital gave men two milkshakes on two different days. The shakes were identical in calories, protein, and fat, but one was high-glycemic and one was low. Four hours later, the high-glycemic shake had produced a sharper drop in blood sugar, more reported hunger, and more activation in the nucleus accumbens, the craving center of the brain. That was David Ludwig's team, published in the *American Journal of Clinical Nutrition*. The sugar high sets up the sugar low, and the low is what sends you back to the pantry. So the afternoon craving isn't a moral event. It's a rebound from lunch.

[VISUAL: Animation: a blood-sugar line spiking and crashing; hormone icons (insulin, androgens, estrogen) wobble as it does.]

Now the fertility link. When blood sugar spikes, insulin spikes with it. Insulin is the hormone that moves sugar out of the blood and into cells, and it is a wonderful hormone in the right amounts. But when it runs high for months, it nudges the ovaries to produce more androgens, hormones that can interfere with regular ovulation. That's why the Endocrine Society's clinical practice guideline on polycystic ovary syndrome puts insulin, diet, and lifestyle right at the center of care. And it isn't only a PCOS story. In a study of nearly four thousand couples who were trying to conceive, published in the journal *Epidemiology* in 2018, drinking one or more sugar-sweetened beverages a day was linked to roughly a twenty percent lower chance of conceiving in any given month, for women and for men alike. Think about that for a moment. The same signal that makes you reach for the sweet drink is quietly working against the goal you care about most. So a craving isn't just a feeling. It's a physiological event with a beginning, a middle, and an end. And that's very good news,

because events can be mapped, and what can be mapped can be changed.

6:00–11:00 IDENTIFYING YOUR TRIGGERS

[VISUAL: Trigger mapping slide: three columns, Emotional · Environmental · Physiological, with examples appearing under each.]

Almost every craving I have ever helped someone trace falls into one of three buckets. Let's walk through them, and as I do, I want you to be thinking about which bucket your nine-o'clock pantry visit lives in.

The first bucket is emotional. Stress, boredom, loneliness, and, interestingly, celebration. Under stress the hormone cortisol rises, and researchers Tanja Adam and Elissa Epel showed in the journal *Physiology and Behavior* that cortisol specifically increases the drive for high-sugar, high-fat comfort foods. Your body is trying to soothe itself. It just picked a tool that only works for about eleven minutes. If your cravings cluster after hard conversations, difficult emails, or the quiet after everyone else goes to bed, you're probably in the emotional bucket.

The second bucket is environmental. The ad on your phone. The candy dish at work. The drive past the bakery on the way

home. A meta-analysis in *Obesity Reviews* by Rebecca Boswell and Hedy Kober pooled dozens of studies and found that reactivity to food cues reliably predicts eating and weight gain. When your brain sees a cue, it does exactly what it evolved to do: it prepares you to eat. Saliva, insulin, attention, all of it. The cue is the trigger, not your weakness. If your cravings show up in the same places, the break room, the car, the couch in front of a particular show, you're in the environmental bucket.

The third bucket is physiological. Blood sugar dips, like the milkshake study. Dehydration, which the brain very often misreads as hunger. And sleep. Matthew Walker's lab at the University of California, Berkeley found in *Nature Communications* that a single night of sleep loss increased the desire for high-calorie foods and dampened activity in the brain regions that help us make careful choices. If you slept five hours last night, tonight's craving was scheduled this morning. If your cravings come at predictable times, mid-afternoon, late evening, the day after a short night, you're in the physiological bucket.

[VISUAL: Cynthia on camera, holding the Triggers Worksheet.]

Here's my honest tip, the one I'd give you if we were sitting across a table. Cravings aren't weakness; they're signals. And the most powerful thing you can do this week is simply write them down. In a systematic review in the Journal of the American Dietetic Association, Lora Burke and her colleagues found that consistent self-monitoring, just tracking, was one of the strongest and most reliable predictors of success in changing eating habits. People I've worked with tell me the same thing in their own words: once they could see the pattern, the craving lost its surprise, and with it, most of its power. A craving you can predict is a craving you can prepare for.

[DEMO: Mindful bite exercise. Cynthia has a single small square of dark chocolate or a strawberry on a plate. She does this slowly, in real time.]

Let me show you a quick tool for interrupting autopilot, and I'd love for you to do it with me. Take one small piece of something you'd normally crave. Before it goes anywhere near your mouth, look at it. Really look: the color, the surface, the way the light sits on it. Now bring it close and smell it. Notice what happens in your body when you smell it, maybe a little pull, a little leaning-forward. That's the anticipation;

that's the dopamine beginning to stir. Now place it on your tongue and don't chew. Just let it sit there for one full breath. Notice the flavor arriving. Now chew, slowly, and pay attention to the exact moment the flavor starts to fade.

[PAUSE — let the demo breathe]

That fade is the whole secret. Most of the pleasure is in the first few seconds; the rest of the bag is chasing a feeling that has already gone. Researchers reviewing mindfulness-based approaches to eating in the journal *Eating Behaviors* found that this kind of attention reliably reduces binge eating and emotional eating. You don't have to give anything up to do this. You have to show up for the first bite.

So here's your work this week, using the Triggers Worksheet. Identify three triggers, one from each bucket if you can. Then, for three days, log every craving you notice: the time, what you wanted, and what was happening around you and inside you. That's it. No changing yet. Just seeing. I'll give you a quick preview of what comes next, so you know where this is going: in Module Two we'll use what you find to choose swaps that actually match your triggers, protein and fat for the physiological bucket, a two-minute pause for the emotional

one, a rearranged pantry for the environmental one. But this week is only about seeing.

11:00–11:40 HEART-LED CLOSE

[VISUAL: Cynthia on camera.]

I want to close with grace, because this is exactly where guilt loves to sneak in. If you log a craving and then eat the thing anyway, you have not failed the assignment. You've completed it. You saw it. Seeing is the entire point of this week. Your future family doesn't need a parent who never craves. They need a parent who knows themselves, and you're becoming that person one entry at a time.

11:40–12:00 ACTION HANDOFF

[VISUAL: End card: "Triggers Worksheet → Identify 3 triggers (40 XP) → Log cravings for 3 days (30 XP) → Discuss in the forum (20 XP)."]

Download the Triggers Worksheet now. Identify your three triggers for forty XP, track your cravings for three days for thirty, and then bring what you found to the forum for twenty. Let's normalize this journey together. I'll see you in Training Three, where we build the mindset that makes all of this stick.

ACTION CALLOUT

RESOURCE Triggers Worksheet.pdf (trigger map + 3-day craving log). **ACTION 1:** Identify 3 triggers, ideally one emotional, one environmental, one physiological (40 XP). **ACTION 2:** Log your cravings for 3 days (30 XP). **ACTION 3:** Discuss one pattern you noticed in the forum (20 XP). **NEXT STEP:** Training 3 · Building a Wellness Mindset.